The Song of What Remains

A Dialogue on Awakening

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A Word Before

This little book borrows nothing it needs you to believe.

It names no god and tells no story of heaven. It quotes no holy book and asks for no faith in any teacher, this one included. It points at one thing only: what you already are, before you add a single thought about it.

You can read it in an evening, but it is not meant to be read once. Read a chapter, then close the book and look. The words are a finger pointing at the moon. Whoever keeps staring at the finger has missed the point.

A seeker speaks, and a teacher answers. In the later chapters the seeker begins to speak from what has been seen. There is no third voice: these two are one mind talking to itself, the part that is tired of searching and the part that never moved.

I. The Question

The seeker said:

1. I have read many books and sat at many feet.
   I have fasted and prayed and counted my breaths.
   Still I am not at peace.
   Tell me plainly: how is a person made free?

2. I do not want another practice to carry.
   I am carrying too many already.
   If there is a door, show me the door.
   If there is no door, tell me that.

The teacher said:

3. You ask how to become free,
   as a wave might ask how to become wet.
   Sit down, and set the question down beside you.
   Let us look at the one who asks.

4. You came here walking on a body.
   You noticed the road, the heat, the dust on your feet.
   Who noticed?
   Not the feet, and not the road.

5. Before you answer with a name, wait.
   The name was given to you.
   Before you answer with a history, wait.
   The history happened to you.

6. What was here before the name arrived,
   and will be here when the history is forgotten?
   Do not answer quickly.
   Quick answers come from memory, and memory is not what you are.

7. You say you are not at peace.
   Peace and unrest come and go like weather.
   You are the one in whom they come and go.
   Does the sky lose its peace because of a storm?

8. You say you have carried many practices.
   Put them down for one breath.

What is left when nothing is being done?
Look there. That is the door you asked for.

9. It is not a door you walk through.
It is the space the walking happens in.
No one has ever stepped outside it,
so no one has ever needed to come in.

10. You will say: "This is too simple. I don't feel free."
Feelings are guests. Freedom is the house.
You have been judging the house
by the moods of its guests.

11. I will not give you anything new.
I will only take away what you have added.
When everything added is gone,
what remains is what you are.

12. Ask your questions, then. Ask all of them.
Each true question, followed to the end,
falls back into the silence it came from.
That silence is the answer that does not need words.

II. Not the Body

The seeker said:

1. I can see that I am not my name.
   But surely I am this body.
   It is born, it eats, it grows tired.
   When it is cut, I bleed.

The teacher said:

2. Look at your hand.
   It is seen. You are the seeing.
   Can the seen be the one who sees it?
   Can the lamp be the thing it lights?

3. As a child, your body was small.
   Now it is large. One day it will be bent and slow.
   Through all its changes, something has not changed.
   It saw the small hand and it sees the large one.

4. Close your eyes and look for the edge of the body.
   You will find sensations: a pressure here, warmth there,
   a tingle, a pulse, a heaviness.
   Where is the solid thing you called your body?

5. There are only sensations, appearing and fading.
   And each one appears to you.
   You are not inside the sensations.
   The sensations are inside you.

6. Pain comes, and you say, “I am in pain.”
   Say instead, “Pain is here, and I am aware of it.”
   The pain does not vanish,
   but the one who knows it is not wounded.

7. Hunger rises. Let it rise.
   Feed the body as you would feed a horse you love.
   But do not mistake the rider’s thirst
   for the horse’s.

8. When you sleep without dreams, where is the body?
   You do not feel it. You do not know it.

Yet when you wake you say, “I slept well.”
Who was there to sleep well?

9. The body is a cloak that was handed to you.
You did not weave it. You will not keep it.
Wear it gently.
Do not mistake the cloak for the one who wears it.

10. To see this is not to hate the body.
The one who hates the body is still bound to it,
as a prisoner is bound to the chain he curses.
Love it, care for it, and know it is not you.

11. When the body is praised, nothing is added to you.
When the body is mocked, nothing is taken.
Beauty and ugliness, strength and weakness,
pass over you like light over a still lake.

12. Sit now, and feel the body breathing on its own.
You do not make the breath.
It is happening, and you are watching it happen.
Rest as the watching.

III. Not the Mind

The seeker said:

1. Then I am the mind.
   I think, I choose, I remember, I plan.
   Even now I am thinking about what you said.
   Surely the thinker is me.

The teacher said:

2. Watch the next thought that comes.
   Do not chase it and do not push it away.
   Simply wait for it, as a cat waits at a hole.
   Where does it come from?

3. You cannot say. It arises from nowhere.
   It stays a moment, then it is gone.
   Where did it go?
   You cannot say that either.

4. Thoughts are like birds crossing an empty sky.
   You have been counting the birds
   and calling yourself the flock.
   Look at the sky.

5. If you were your thoughts, then between two thoughts
   you would stop existing.
   But in the gap you are fully here,
   quiet and awake.

6. Memory says, “I am the one who did this and suffered that.”
   But memory is only another thought, appearing now.
   The past has no address.
   It lives nowhere but in this moment’s remembering.

7. The future too is a thought appearing now:
   a picture of tomorrow, painted with today’s fear or hope.
   You have spent your life between two paintings
   and missed the wall they hang on.

8. You say, “I choose.”
   Find the moment of choosing.

You will find a thought, then another,
and then you find the choice already made.

9. This is not a cause for despair.
It is a great relief.
The weight you carried as the doer of everything
was never yours to carry.

10. Feelings move through the mind like rivers:
joy, envy, grief, longing, shame.
You are not the river.
You are the ground it runs over.

11. A dark mood is not a dark self.
It is a cloud, and clouds are only weather.
The weather changes.
What it changes in does not.

12. Do not try to silence the mind.
That is a mind trying to silence itself:
a dog chasing its tail.
Let it talk. You are the listening.

13. When thinking slows, do not say, "Now I am free."
When thinking races, do not say, "Now I am lost."
Both are scenery passing a window.
You are the one looking out.

14. Ask, "Who is aware of this thought?"
Do not answer with another thought.
Let the question point back,
and stay where it points.

IV. The Witness

The seeker said:

1. If I am not the body and not the mind,
   then I am nothing.
   This frightens me.
   Am I only an empty space?

The teacher said:

2. You are not nothing. You are not something either.
   "Something" is a thing that can be seen.
   "Nothing" is what you call the absence of things.
   You are what sees both.

3. Call it awareness, if you need a word.
   But do not make the word into a thing.
   It has no color, no size, no edge.
   It is closer to you than your breath.

4. Everything you have ever known appeared in it:
   your mother's face, the taste of rice, the fear at night,
   the joy of your first success, the shame of your first failure.
   None of them stained it.

5. A mirror shows fire and is not burned.
   It shows a flood and is not wet.
   It shows a corpse and does not die.
   You are like this, and more than this.

6. A mirror needs light. You are the light.
   A mirror has a back. You have no back.
   A mirror can be broken.
   What could break you?

7. Do not go looking for awareness.
   It is the looking itself.
   An eye cannot see itself,
   yet it never doubts that it sees.

8. When you hear a bird, do not ask, "Who hears?"
   as if you must find a hearer somewhere.

Just notice that hearing is happening,
effortless and clear. That is you.

9. You have never once been absent from your own life.
Every experience you have had, you were there.
This presence, never missing,
is the one thing you can be sure of.

10. All else can be doubted.
The world may be a dream. The body may be a dream.
But that something is aware, here, now,
cannot be doubted even by the one who doubts.

11. Rest in this certainty.
It needs no proof and no teacher.
It was here before you met me
and it will be here when you have forgotten my face.

12. Do not try to keep it.
You cannot lose it, so there is nothing to keep.
Only notice, again and again,
what has been noticing all along.

13. At first this will feel like a practice.
Later it will feel like coming home.
At last there will be no feeling about it at all,
only this, plain and open, like the morning.

V. The Seeker's First Wonder

The seeker said:

1. Wait. Wait.
   Something has turned around.
   I was looking out through these eyes for myself,
   and I was the space the looking happened in.

2. How strange, and how ordinary!
   Nothing has changed: the wall, the window, the noise outside.
   And everything has changed,
   because none of it is happening to someone.

3. I have been chasing my own shadow
   and weeping because it would not stop running.
   Now I am standing still,
   and the shadow is still too.

4. I was looking for peace as for a lost key.
   The peace was the room I was searching in.
   How many years I turned it upside down
   when all I had to do was sit in it.

5. I thought I was a small thing in a large world.
   But the world appears in me:
   mountains, cities, stars, and all their people.
   Who could be smaller than what holds them?

6. Yet I do not feel big.
   Big and small are measurements,
   and there is nothing here to measure.
   There is only this open knowing.

7. I am laughing, and I do not know why.
   Perhaps because I searched so hard
   for what could never be far away.
   The joke was on the one who searched.

8. Thoughts are still coming, but they are light now,
   like leaves blowing across a courtyard.
   I see them, and I do not run after them.
   Even when I do, I know I have not moved.

9. Body, I thank you. You carried me here.
   Mind, I thank you. You asked all the questions.
   You were never my enemies.
   You were the road, and the road has ended.

10. I have nothing to defend now,
    because nothing of mine can be harmed.
    Let them praise. Let them blame.
    Wind blows, and the sky does not argue.

11. Is this freedom? I do not want to name it.
    A name is a box, and this has no walls.
    Let it stay nameless.
    Let it stay as it is.

12. Teacher, is this the end?
    Or is this only the beginning?

The teacher said:

13. It is neither the end nor the beginning.
    You have only stopped looking away.
    Stay with it as you would stay with a sleeping child:
    gently, without grasping, and without fear.

14. The old habits will return.
    Let them come and see them clearly.
    A seed that has been roasted
    looks like a seed, but it will not grow.

VI. The World as a Dream

The seeker said:

1. If everything appears in awareness,
   is the world unreal?
   My mother is real. The rice is real.
   The suffering of the poor is real.

The teacher said:

2. Do not throw away the world to grasp the truth.
   That is like smashing the screen to find the light.
   The world is real as appearance.
   It is not real as something apart from you.

3. In a dream there are mountains and rivers,
   friends and enemies, hunger and feasts.
   While the dream lasts, all of it is real.
   On waking, where did the mountains go?

4. They were made of the dreamer.
   The rivers were the dreamer, and the enemies too.
   Nothing in the dream was ever outside
   the one who was dreaming it.

5. The waking world is solid, you say.
   But solidity is a sensation,
   and sensation is a knowing,
   and knowing is what you are.

6. Find a world that is not known.
   Find a sound no one hears, a color no one sees.
   You cannot. Each time you look, there is knowing.
   Where is the line between the world and the knowing?

7. This does not make your mother a phantom.
   It makes her closer than you thought.
   She is not out there across a gap.
   She is here, in the same light that you are.

8. The suffering of the poor is not made smaller by this.
   It is made more intimate.

When there is no wall between you and the world,
whose pain is it?

9. The one who says, “It is all a dream, so nothing matters,”
is still asleep and dreaming of being wise.
The one who wakes still feeds the hungry.
Now they feed them as their own body.

10. Gold becomes rings, bracelets, chains, and coins.
Names and shapes change; the gold does not.
Look at the world, then look at its gold.
You do not have to melt the ring to see it.

11. Clay becomes pots, and the pots break.
The clay was never broken.
Things are born and die.
That in which they are born and die does neither.

12. Live in the world fully.
Work, love, build, weep, celebrate.
Only remember what the world is made of,
as a dancer remembers the floor.

VII. On Fear and Death

The seeker said:

1. I am afraid of dying.
   Not of the pain, but of the ending:
   the dark, the not-being, the forgetting.
   Can this understanding cure that?

The teacher said:

2. Look at what you fear.
   You fear the end of experience.
   But have you ever experienced
   the absence of experience?

3. You cannot. Where there is experience, you are there.
   Where you are not, there is no one to miss anything.
   The darkness you imagine is a picture,
   and a picture needs someone to see it.

4. Every night you lie down in deep sleep,
   and every night the world, the body, and the name disappear.
   You do not fear sleep.
   You long for it.

5. What dies is what was born:
   this body, this story, this bundle of habits.
   Were you born? Find the moment.
   You will find only the body's beginning, told to you by others.

6. The wave rises from the sea and falls back into it.
   Was the water ever born?
   Did it ever die?
   It only changed its shape for a while.

7. Fear is a contraction, a closing around a point.
   It says, "This small thing is me and must be protected."
   See the point, and see what surrounds it.
   Fear loosens like a fist that has forgotten what it held.

8. Do not pretend not to be afraid.
   Fear will still come; it is the body's old song.

Let it sing.
Notice that the one listening is not trembling.

9. Fear of loss is the same as fear of death.
   Losing your wealth, your love, your place, your name:
   each is a small dying.
   Each can be met with the same open eyes.

10. Whoever has died before dying
    walks lightly in the world.
    Nothing can be taken from them
    because they hold nothing as theirs.

11. Think of the ones you have lost.
    Where were they ever, except in this knowing?
    They have changed their shape.
    They have not left the light you are.

12. When death comes, let it come as evening comes.
    The sun does not go anywhere.
    The earth turns.
    You were never the earth.

VIII. On Desire

The seeker said:

1. I still want things.
   I want success, respect, money, love.
   I want to matter.
   Must I kill these wants to be free?

The teacher said:

2. You cannot kill a want by wanting to kill it.
   That is one desire fighting another,
   and the war itself is the bondage.
   Look at desire instead.

3. When you want something, what do you really want?
   You want the moment after you get it,
   when the wanting stops
   and you are at rest.

4. That rest is not in the object.
   It is what you are when wanting pauses.
   The object only gave you a reason to stop looking away.
   You have been buying your own peace back from the world.

5. See this once, clearly,
   and desire loses its iron grip.
   It may still come,
   but it comes as a guest, not as a master.

6. The thirsty man runs toward the mirage.
   When he learns it is a mirage, he still sees the water shimmer.
   But he does not run.
   He sits in the shade and smiles.

7. Enjoy what comes. Release what goes.
   A river does not grasp at its banks.
   It touches every stone
   and keeps no stone.

8. You want to matter.
   To whom? To a crowd of passing thoughts in other people?

You are what gives every face its light.
How could you not matter?

9. Ambition is not the problem.
   The problem is believing you will be complete
   when the ambition is fulfilled.
   Build from wholeness, not toward it.

10. The one who works from lack
    is always hungry, even at the feast.
    The one who works from fullness
    gives freely and is not emptied.

11. When a want arises, ask:
    "Who wants?"
    Follow the question home.
    The want will be there, but no one will be bound by it.

12. Not wanting is just another wanting.
    The free person neither chases nor runs.
    They walk through the marketplace of the world
    like a child among toys they do not need to own.

IX. On Doing and Not-Doing

The seeker said:

1. If I am not the doer, should I stop acting?
   Should I leave my studies, my plans, my work?
   Should I sit in a cave
   and let the world turn without me?

The teacher said:

2. The one who goes to a cave to stop doing
   is doing a great deal.
   They have only changed what they do
   and where they do it.

3. Actions happen. Bodies move. Words are spoken.
   Plans are made and broken.
   All this goes on like rain and wind,
   with or without the thought "I am doing it."

4. Drop the thought, not the action.
   The hands will still work.
   The mind will still plan.
   But a weight will be gone from them.

5. Watch the body walk.
   Does it need you to decide each step?
   The breath breathes, the heart beats, the food is digested.
   Most of your life is lived without a doer.

6. Now see that the rest is the same.
   The choices, too, arise like weather.
   This is not fate or chance.
   It is simply what is happening.

7. Then act as you are moved to act,
   cleanly and without hesitation.
   Do not cling to the result.
   Results are another season of the weather.

8. Success comes; let it come.
   Failure comes; let it come.

The one who sees both arriving
is not the one who succeeds or fails.

9. Act as an actor plays a king or a beggar,
fully, with tears or laughter,
knowing all along
that when the play ends, the actor goes home.

10. Do not wait to be free before you act.
Do not act in order to become free.
Act, and be free while acting,
as water is wet while it flows.

11. The busy one and the still one look different.
Inside, they may be the same.
Freedom does not live in stillness or in movement.
It lives in the one who sees both.

12. When there is nothing to be done, rest.
When there is something to be done, do it.
This is the whole teaching on action.
Everything else is commentary.

X. On Practice and Its End

The seeker said:

1. Should I meditate?
   Should I chant, or fast, or keep vows?
   Should I serve others, or study, or be silent?
   What practice leads here?

The teacher said:

2. No practice leads to where you already are.
   Practice can only remove what blocks the view.
   Use it like soap:
   wash, then rinse it away.

3. If sitting quietly helps you notice, sit.
   If walking helps, walk.
   If serving helps, serve.
   But do not make the method into a god.

4. Many grow proud of their practice.
   "I have meditated ten thousand hours."
   Who counted? Who is proud?
   The practice has become a new cage, gilded with merit.

5. You use a thorn to remove a thorn,
   then you throw both away.
   Use one thought to remove another,
   then let both go.

6. The simplest practice is this:
   notice what is noticing.
   Again and again, gently,
   until the noticing notices itself.

7. You will forget. That is fine.
   Forgetting happens in awareness too.
   Even the moment of forgetting
   is held in what you cannot forget.

8. Do not count your progress.
   The sky does not get bluer each day.

What changes is only how often
you stop looking at clouds.

9. A day will come when practice drops away by itself,
like scaffolding from a finished house.
Do not pull it down early.
Do not cling to it after.

10. Effort and effortlessness are two sides of one coin.
At first there is effort to see.
Then there is effortless seeing.
Then there is no one who sees or makes an effort.

11. If someone says, “This will take many lifetimes,”
ask: when is a lifetime, except now?
If someone says, “It happens in an instant,”
ask: which instant is not this one?

12. Practice when it helps. Rest when it does not.
Be kind to yourself along the way.
The harshness of a seeker toward themselves
is only the old self in robes.

XI. On Others and On Love

The seeker said:

1. If I am this awareness,
   what are other people?
   Are they in me, or am I in them?
   Am I alone?

The teacher said:

2. You are not alone.
   There is no one apart from you to be alone from.
   Loneliness is the feeling of a wall.
   Look for the wall.

3. The light in your eyes and the light in theirs
   is not two lights.
   Bodies are many, minds are many,
   but the knowing in them is one.

4. When you look into a friend's face
   and something in you softens and opens,
   that is not a feeling between two people.
   That is the one recognizing itself.

5. This is why love exists:
   the separate self remembering, for a moment,
   that it was never separate.
   Love is a crack in the wall that was never there.

6. Hatred is the opposite remembering.
   It insists the wall is real.
   It needs an enemy outside
   to believe it has a self inside.

7. Do not try to love everyone.
   You will fail and feel guilty.
   See through the wall instead.
   Love will flow where it flows, without your effort.

8. Be kind, not because a law commands it,
   but because the other's pain is not foreign to you.

The hand does not help the foot from duty.
They are one body.

9. When someone harms you, see their fear.
It is your own fear in another costume.
You do not have to let them harm you again.
But you do not have to make them your enemy.

10. Forgive, and know there was no one to forgive.
Forgive yourself, and know there was no one to blame.
What remains when blame is gone
is quiet, warm, and wide.

11. Parents, brothers, sisters, teachers, strangers:
all appear in the same light.
Honor them, care for them, argue with them,
and know you are not divided from them.

12. Love without clinging is the freest love.
It holds the beloved like water held in an open hand:
nothing is squeezed,
nothing is lost.

XII. The Teacher Tests the Seeker

The teacher said:

1. Tell me: if I insulted you now,
   called you a fool before the whole village,
   what would happen?

The seeker said:

2. The face would burn. The heart would race.
   Old words would rise to defend this name.
   And all of it would be seen,
   and the seeing would not burn.

The teacher said:

3. If you lost everything tomorrow:
   your family, your future, your health?

The seeker said:

4. There would be grief, deep grief.
   I will not pretend there would not.
   But grief is a river,
   and I have found the ground beneath rivers.

The teacher said:

5. If you were given great power,
   the power to judge others, to command, to grow rich?

The seeker said:

6. I would be afraid of it.
   Not for what it could do to me,
   but for how easily it makes the small self loud again.
   I would use it lightly, if at all, and only to serve.

The teacher said:

7. That fear is wisdom. Keep it.
   Many who glimpsed the truth were swallowed by power,
   because they thought the glimpse made them safe.
   Nothing makes the body-mind safe. Only clarity guards it.

8. If I told you that everything you have seen is wrong,
   that you are only a body, and death ends all?

The seeker said:

9. Then your words would appear,
   and be heard,
   in what I am.
   Who would be there to be convinced?

The teacher said:

10. Good. Do not believe me. Do not believe yourself.
    Belief is for what cannot be seen.
    What you are does not need belief.
    It needs only not to be overlooked.

XIII. When Doubt Returns

The seeker said:

1. Teacher, it is gone.
   Yesterday I was the open sky.
   Today I am small again,
   angry, anxious, lost in thoughts.

The teacher said:

2. Who noticed that it is gone?
   Was the noticing gone?
   The sky does not vanish when clouds gather.
   You have only become interested in clouds again.

3. Do not grieve the experience you had.
   Experiences come and go; that is their nature.
   What you saw was not an experience.
   It is what all experiences happen in.

4. A glimpse is like lightning at night.
   For an instant the whole land is lit.
   Then the dark returns,
   but you know now that the land is there.

5. The old habits have worn deep paths.
   Thought runs down them like water down a hill.
   Do not fight the water.
   Keep noticing the hill.

6. Anger is here? Let it be here,
   and see in what it is here.
   Anxiety is here? The same.
   Nothing is wrong except the belief that something is wrong.

7. Even “I am lost” is a thought.
   It appears in the open space
   that has never once been lost.
   See the thought for what it is.

8. The seeker wants to be awake all the time.
   That is the last trick of the seeker:

to make awakening into a state
that it can own and protect.

9. Let it go, the wanting to stay awake.
   Let even the awakening go.
   What remains when you let go of letting go?
   That is not a state. That is home.

10. Doubt is a friend if you follow it to the end.
    Doubt everything until only the doubter is left.
    Then doubt the doubter.
    What remains cannot be doubted.

11. Be patient. Not because time will bring it,
    but because impatience is only another cloud.
    The sun has always been shining.
    The weather is not your business.

XIV. The Ocean and the Waves

The teacher said:

1. Listen to a parable, the only one in this book.
   A wave once grew tired of being a wave.
   It feared the shore, where it would break.
   It envied the bigger waves and pitied the smaller.

2. It asked the other waves, “What is the ocean?”
   Some said it was far away, beneath the deep.
   Some said it was a place good waves reached after breaking.
   Some said there was no ocean, only waves.

3. The wave tried to sink down to find it.
   It tried to rise high enough to see it.
   It practiced being calm, and it practiced being strong.
   Still it did not find the ocean.

4. At last, exhausted, it stopped trying.
   It simply rested in its own wetness.
   And in that rest, it noticed
   it was made of the very thing it sought.

5. Its height was ocean, its foam was ocean,
   its fear, its envy, its breaking were ocean.
   The shore it feared was only the ocean
   changing its shape.

6. The wave still moved. It still rose and fell.
   It still met other waves, and sometimes collided.
   But it no longer feared the shore.
   It no longer believed it was a wave in the ocean.
   It knew it was the ocean, waving.

The seeker said:

7. I am that wave.
   I have tried to rise and sink and calm myself.
   I have feared the shore and envied the great.
   And I have always been water.

8. What a relief, to be so ordinary!

No special wave, no chosen wave.
Only the ocean, as everything,
shaped for a moment as this.

XV. Beyond the Witness

The teacher said:

1. I told you that you are the witness.
   That was a stepping stone. Now step off it.
   A witness needs something to witness.
   Where there is a witness, there are still two.

2. Look: is there a gap
   between the seeing and the seen?
   Between the hearing and the sound?
   Find the place where one ends and the other begins.

3. There is no such place.
   The sound is the hearing.
   The tree is the seeing.
   The knowing and the known were never two.

4. First you learned, “I am not the world.”
   That cleared away the false self.
   Now see, “I am not separate from the world.”
   That clears away the one who stood apart.

5. The first is like a man leaving a crowded room.
   The second is like the room dissolving,
   and the man with it,
   and only the light remaining.

6. Do not stop at emptiness.
   Emptiness, held as an idea, is the subtlest self.
   It says, “I am nothing,” and sits proudly on nothing.
   Let even that be seen through.

7. What remains has no name.
   It is not one, because “one” needs a second to count against.
   It is not many, because nothing is outside it.
   Say “not two,” and then be silent.

8. Here there is no seeker and no teacher.
   There is no bondage and no freedom.
   There is no path and no goal.
   There is just this, exactly as it is.

9. The tea is hot. The street is noisy. The heart is beating.
   Nothing special.
   Nothing ever needed to be special.
   This was always it.

XVI. The Free One

The teacher said:

1. You ask what a free person is like.
   I will tell you, but do not use it as a measuring stick.
   The free do not measure themselves.
   Only the bound keep score.

2. They eat when hungry and sleep when tired.
   They work when there is work.
   Their days look like other people's days.
   Their inner weather is clear.

3. They are not always calm.
   They may laugh loudly or weep openly.
   But nothing sticks to them for long,
   as rain does not stick to glass.

4. They do not need to be right.
   They argue without hatred, lose without bitterness,
   win without boasting.
   They can change their mind easily, because their mind is not them.

5. They do not need to teach unless asked.
   They do not need followers.
   If people come, they serve.
   If people leave, they bless.

6. They are honest, because they have no image to protect.
   They are kind, because they see no stranger.
   They are brave, because the worst has already happened:
   the one who could lose has been seen through.

7. They are not perfect.
   The body still ages. The character still has its quirks.
   Freedom is not the polishing of a person.
   It is the end of mistaking yourself for one.

8. They do not cling to solitude or to company,
   to wealth or to poverty,
   to fame or to obscurity.
   Whatever comes, they meet it. Whatever goes, they let it go.

9. They are like the sky over a city:
   above the temples and the brothels alike,
   over the rich and the poor,
   touching all, held by none.

10. If you meet such a person, do not worship them.
    That would be looking away again.
    Look at what shines in them
    and see it shining in you.

XVII. The Song of the Free

The seeker said:

1. I am not the body, yet I do not reject it.
   I am not the mind, yet I let it play.
   I am not the world, yet the world is my face.
   I am what remains when everything is let go.

2. I have no birthday, for I was never born.
   I keep no deathday, for I will never die.
   The cloak was given and the cloak will be taken.
   The one who wore it stays.

3. Praise falls on me like flowers on water.
   Blame falls like stones on the sky.
   The water does not keep the flowers.
   The sky does not keep the stones.

4. I have no country, though the body has a passport.
   I have no religion, though I bow to all that is sincere.
   I have no rank, though the world will give me titles.
   I am the space in which countries and titles appear.

5. I have nothing to prove.
   I have nothing to gain.
   I have nothing to fear.
   What a lightness, after so many years of carrying!

6. The poor man and the king appear in me equally.
   The saint and the thief are lit by the same light.
   I do not approve of all they do,
   but I see no one outside myself.

7. Let the body work. Let it build, learn, earn, serve.
   Let the mind plan its plans.
   Let the heart love whom it loves.
   I watch, and I am not watching. I am all of it.

8. I was looking for freedom.
   Freedom was what I was looking with.
   I was looking for truth.
   Truth was the one who looked.

9. No master gave me this.
   No book gave me this.
   No practice earned it.
   It was here, waiting to be noticed, like the air.

10. Where shall I go now?
    Wherever the feet go.
    What shall I do now?
    Whatever is given to do.

11. I bow to the teacher, who was my own clarity.
    I bow to the seeker, who was my own longing.
    I bow to the world, which is my own face.
    I bow, and there is no one bowing.

12. Wonderful! Wonderful!
    Nothing has happened,
    and everything is free.

XVIII. Silence

The teacher said:

1. Now close this book.
2. Everything said here
   was said to bring you back
   to what no words can reach.
3. Do not keep the words.
   Keep nothing.
   What is kept can be lost.
4. Look up from the page.
   What is looking?
5. Rest there.
6. . . .

A Note for the Reader

This book stands in a long line of texts on non-duality, which hold that awareness and its contents are not two. Two short classics in that line, the *Ashtavakra Gita* and the *Avadhuta Gita*, inspired its form: a teacher's pointing and a student's songs of recognition.

On purpose, it leaves out every name, deity, ritual, and technical term those traditions use, so that a reader of any faith, or of none, can test it against their own experience. Every verse is new writing, not a translation.

One caution. Insight into what you are does not replace care for your body and mind. If a passage stirs up distress, or seems to say that nothing matters, put the book down and talk to someone you trust. A true understanding of non-duality makes a person kinder and more responsible, never less.